More happily for Humayun – for whom the loss was not of an aunt alone, but of a strategic ally – he was joined, en route, by his youngest brother, Hindal. This was good news in itself, of course, but also because it signalled a changing wind. As Abul Fazl puts it, Hindal's coming was a 'preface to the advent of many others'. Such was the wave of allegiance that swept to Humayun's side, in fact, that by the time the returning emperor's expanding army came face to face with Kamran's, outside Kabul, that 'black-hearted . . . prince'[27] had decided to leave without a fight. As night fell, Kamran crept back into the fort, gathered his son Ibrahim and some of his women, and left.

'*Be jang girift mulk-i-Kabul az we*' was one chronogram for the date, 'without a battle he took the country of Kabul from him'.[28] On 17 November 1545, at an auspicious time two hours into the night, Humayun marched into the city in which he was born. After five long years of exile, he was finally home.

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And he was hungry. It was the month of Ramzan and Humayun hadn't eaten all day, so he sent Jouher to one of the begums in the fort – a widow of Babur's – to ask if she would send him a little dinner from her kitchen. Of course she would: Jouher and a chamberlain were soon back with a broth and a meat-and-veg curry, both made of beef. The table was laid, Humayun was seated, his spoon held ready, when suddenly the emperor drew back his hand. Was it *beef* he was to eat? 'Oh, unfortunate Kamran!' he exclaimed. 'Was this the mode of your own existence? And did you feed the Asylum of Chastity [Babur's widow] on the flesh of cows? What! Could you not afford to keep a few goats[29] for her subsistence? . . . What! Could not we, his four sons, support . . . [her] as he did?' So dismayed was Humayun by this unfitting meal – beef was such poor fare to the Mughals, it seems – that he refused a single bite of it, only downing a glass of sherbet instead.[30]

Still, though dinner was a disaster, the emperor was able to satisfy a far deeper longing that night. Two years after he had left him behind, Humayun met his son.

Humayun offered prayers of gratitude and alms in joy, but we must wait